

Swan Lake's premiere. He decided to marry, partly to protect his family from rumors and also because, as he told Modest, "Homosexuality and pedagogy cannot abide in harmony with one another." He had fallen in love with another student, violinist Iosif Kotek, for whom he later wrote his Violin Concerto (Kotek would not give its premiere, for fear of exposing their relationship). But in 1877, Tchaikovsky received some startling letters from a former student, Antonina Milyukova, in which she declared her love for him. It is thought that his opera Eugene Onegin, based on Pushkin's poem in which Tatyana approaches Onegin with a love letter, was inspired by this event. Tchaikovsky duly married Antonina.

The marriage was a disaster. In despair, the composer attempted suicide by walking into the Moscow River, intending to contract pneumonia so that it would seem he had died by natural causes. In the end, he did not even catch a cold. He did, however, experience a severe nervous breakdown. The pair soon separated, but never actually divorced.

A more rewarding relationship arrived in a similarly strange way. In 1876, Nadezhda von Meck, widow of a railroad magnate, had begun to commission music from Tchaikovsky; she went on to provide him with an annual allowance, enabling him to devote himself fully to composition. The couple agreed that they should never meet; twice, they accidentally came face to face, yet passed one another without speaking. Over 14 years, their friendship unfolded in more than 1,200 letters. Tchaikovsky secretly dedicated his Symphony No. 4—a work characterized by a powerful Fate motif—to her.